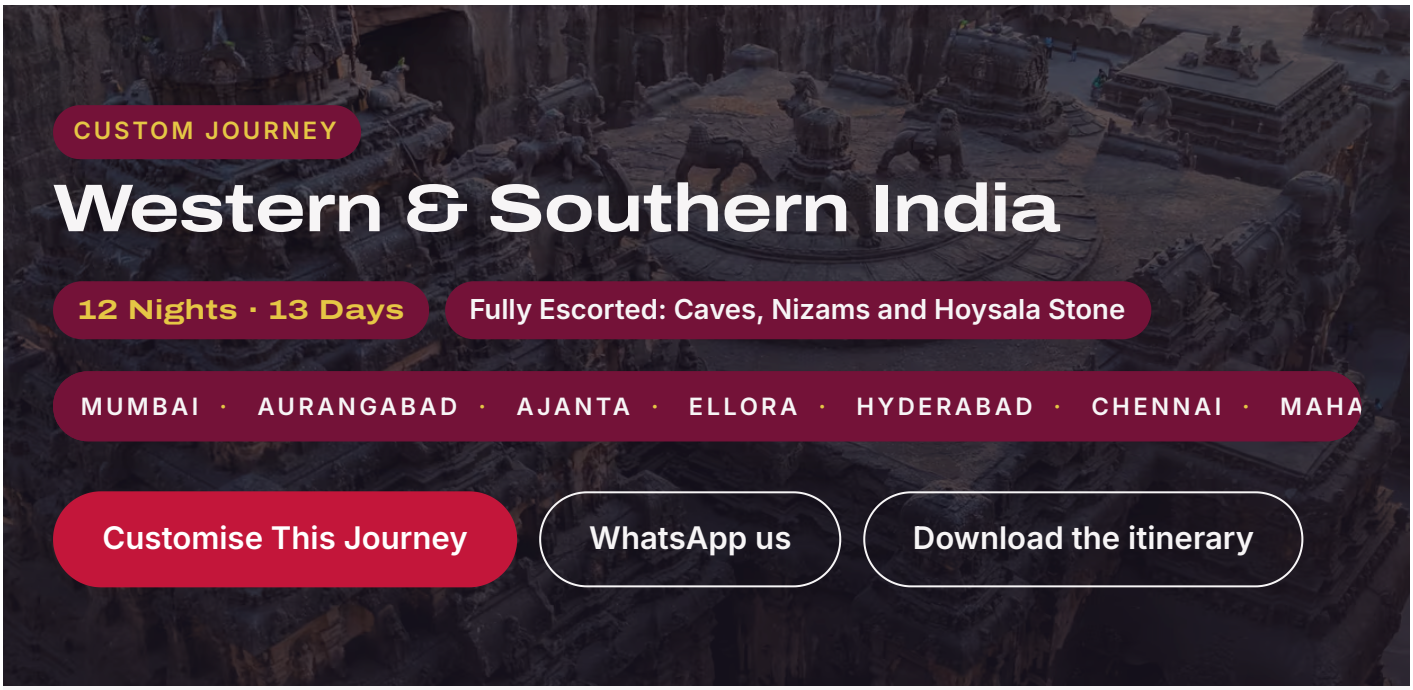
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DURATION
12 Nights · 13 Days

ROUTE
Mumbai → Bengaluru

PACE
Active

BEST SEASON
October to March

IDEAL FOR
Couples, Groups, Solo

India rarely reveals herself all at once. She unfolds, cave by cave, temple by temple, palace by palace. This thirteen-day journey was designed for travellers who want more than a checklist: a passage through two-thousand-year-old rock-cut sanctuaries, Mughal and Nizami courts, Dravidian temple cities carved from single boulders, and the palaces of maharajas who once ruled kingdoms the size of small nations.

You will trace the chisel-marks of monks who cut Buddhist prayer halls into solid basalt at Ajanta and Ellora, stand beneath minarets raised when Hyderabad was young, watch the tide roll over shore temples older than most nations, and walk the marble halls of Mysore's royal family. This is a fully escorted itinerary: private transfers, English-speaking local guides, and a pace built for genuine discovery rather than a rushed

checklist. Every stop is handled for you, so all that is left to do is arrive, look up, and be amazed.

Journey Highlights

- **Spend** a full day at the Ajanta Caves: 2nd-century-BC rock-cut Buddhist art, hidden by jungle for centuries before rediscovery.
- **Explore** all 34 caves of Ellora, where Hindu, Buddhist and Jain monuments share a single UNESCO-listed hillside.
- **Walk** beneath the minarets of Charminar and through the Persian-Arabic courtyards of Chowmahalla Palace in Hyderabad.
- **Watch** the Bay of Bengal break against the 1,300-year-old Shore Temple at Mahabalipuram.
- **Discover** Kanchipuram, the Land of a Thousand Temples and home of India's finest handwoven silk.
- **Marvel** at the Hoysala stone-carvers' masterworks at Belur and Halebid: star-shaped temples with a 42-metre pillar balanced without a base.
- **Tour** the fairy-tale Mysore Palace and the illuminated Brindavan Gardens beside the Krishnarajasagar Dam.
- **Go** on safari at Bannerghatta National Park outside Bengaluru, among tigers, lions and bears.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	**Mumbai**	Elephanta & Kanheri Caves, Haji Ali Dargah, Juhu Beach

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 02	**Aurangabad**	Fly in, settle into the historic Mughal city
Day 03	**Ajanta Caves**	A full day among 2,000-year-old Buddhist rock art
Day 04	**Ellora Caves**	34 rock-cut temples; overnight train to Hyderabad
Day 05	**Hyderabad**	Charminar, Chowmahalla Palace, Qutb Shahi Tombs
Day 06	**Hyderabad**	Golconda Fort, Hussain Sagar, Ramoji Film City
Day 07	**Chennai**	Marina Beach, St. Thomas Basilica, Vandalur Zoo
Day 08	**Mahabalipuram & Kanchipuram**	Shore Temple, Pancha Rathas, the silk-city temples
Day 09	**Mysore**	Overnight train into the City of Palaces
Day 10	**Belur & Halebid**	Hoysala masterpieces: Chennakeshava & Hoysaleswara
Day 11	**Mysore**	Mysore Palace, Jaganmohan Palace, Brindavan Gardens
Day 12	**Bengaluru**	Cubbon Park, Bannerghatta safari, Bangalore Palace
Day 13	**Departure**	Onward flight from Bengaluru

Day by Day

Expand all

Day 01 Mumbai: City of Dreams

Touch down in Maharashtra's electric capital and settle in with your guide before the city sweeps you up. Begin at the Elephanta Caves, basalt shrines carved between 400 and 800 AD and still watched over by their original sculpture. Then Haji Ali Dargah, the mausoleum-mosque that appears to float on the Arabian Sea, and the Kanheri Caves, famed for 109 rock-cut entrances, cisterns and inscriptions. Wind down at Juhu Beach as the sun goes over the water, and do not leave without a proper vada pav.

Overnight in Mumbai

Day 02 Aurangabad: Onward to the Mughal City

Fly · Mumbai to Aurangabad

A short flight to Aurangabad, one of India's oldest and most storied cities, renamed Fatehnagar under Mughal rule before reclaiming its own name. Check in and take the afternoon to rest. The city's real treasures are a day's drive away in either direction, and they deserve you awake.

Overnight in Aurangabad

Day 03 Ajanta Caves: A Day Inside Living Art

Today is given entirely to Ajanta. Carved between the 2nd century BC and the 6th century AD, these monolithic caverns hold some of the finest surviving classical Indian painting and sculpture anywhere: Buddhist stupas, pillared prayer halls, and walls and ceilings alive with two millennia of devotional art. The site was lost to dense jungle for centuries before its rediscovery, which is precisely why so much of the paintwork survives.

Overnight in Aurangabad

Day 04 Ellora Caves: Three Faiths, One Hillside

Overnight train · to Hyderabad

Today belongs to Ellora, cut into the Charanandri Hills by the Kalachuri, Chalukya and Rashtrakuta dynasties and known locally as Verul Leni. Its 34 caves set Hindu, Buddhist and Jain monuments side by side on a single UNESCO-listed hillside, a piece of religious coexistence in stone that has no real equivalent. Do not miss the Vishvakarma Cave, nicknamed the Carpenter's Cave, or the Dashavatara Cave dedicated to Vishnu. In the evening, board the overnight train south.

Overnight aboard the train

Day 05 Hyderabad: City of Nizams

Arrive in the Telangana capital, long known as the city of Mughals and Nizams, and settle in on the banks of the Musi. The tour begins at Charminar, raised by Qutb Shah when he moved his capital here, its minarets looking out across the old town. Then Chowmahalla Palace, seat of the Nizams, where Persian-Arabic architecture unfolds across four palaces, courtyards and fountains around the Khilwat Mubarak. The day closes at the Qutb Shahi Tombs: seven dynastic kings, Persian and Naskh calligraphy, and enamel tilework still holding its colour.

Overnight in Hyderabad

Day 06 Hyderabad: Forts, Lakes and Film Studios

Golconda Fort first, a granite hill fortress with an 800-year-old tree in its grounds and a tunnel running beneath the Durbar Hall. Then Hussain Sagar, the heart-shaped lake at the city's centre with its Buddha rising from the water, worth taking a boat out for. For something entirely different, Ramoji Film City, the largest film studio complex in the world, with theme-park rides and live shows attached.

Overnight in Hyderabad

Day 07 Chennai: Gateway to the South

Fly · Hyderabad to Chennai

South to the Tamil Nadu capital, a city as proud of its history as of its standing as the automobile hub of India. Begin at Marina Beach, the second-longest urban beach in the world and busy with kite-flyers and vendors. Then St. Thomas Cathedral Basilica, rebuilt in neo-Gothic style in 1896 over the tomb of the apostle, and Vandalur Zoo, India's first and South Asia's largest, 600 hectares of relatively open habitat for tiger, elephant and lion.

Overnight in Chennai

Day 08 Mahabalipuram & Kanchipuram: Temples in Stone and Silk

Drive · full-day excursion

A full day across two sacred landscapes. At Mahabalipuram, temple complexes commissioned by the Pallava kings over more than two centuries: the Shore Temple, built between 700 and 728 AD on the edge of the Bay of Bengal and one of the Seven Pagodas, and the Pancha Rathas, five monolithic shrines cut for the Pandava brothers. Then Kanchipuram, former Pallava capital and the source of India's finest handwoven silk: the gold-crowned Kamakshi Amman Temple, one of the 51 Shakti Peethas, and the Ekambareswarar Temple with the world's sixth-tallest gopuram.

Overnight in Chennai

Day 09 Mysore: Into the City of Palaces

Overnight train · to Mysore

The overnight train carries you into Karnataka and the former seat of the Wodeyar kingdom, which ruled here for more than five centuries. Mysore takes its name from the demon Mahishasura, slain by the goddess Chamundeshwari; it was also one of Asia's first planned cities and holds India's oldest university. Arrive, check in, and settle in for the days ahead.

Overnight in Mysore

Day 10 Belur & Halebid: The Hoysala Masterworks

Drive · full-day excursion

To Belur, once the Hoysala capital, for the Chennakeshava Temple, a Dravidian masterpiece to Vishnu, best known for a freestanding 42-metre gravity pillar that stands without base or foundation. In the afternoon, Halebidu and the Hoysaleswara Temple, its walls given over entirely to monumental carving, plus an archaeological site holding more than a hundred sculptures and inscriptions from the 12th and 13th centuries, and the soapstone Kedareshwar Temple raised by King Veera Ballala II.

Overnight in Mysore

Day 11 Mysore: Palaces and Gardens

A day for the royal legacy. Mysore Palace, rebuilt after a fire in a blend of Indo-Saracenic, Rajput, Islamic and Gothic, now holding the family's jewellery, paintings and regalia. Then the Jaganmohan Palace of 1861, a royal residence turned exhibition hall. The day closes at the Brindavan Gardens beside the Krishnarajasagar Dam, where the terraced flowerbeds and the choreographed fountains are worth staying out for.

Overnight in Mysore

Day 12 Bengaluru: Gardens, Safari and a Tudor Palace

Drive · Mysore to Bengaluru

By road to Bengaluru, as well known for its green spaces as for its technology. Cubbon Park is a hundred acres dating to 1870, with gardens, a library and a lively weekend crowd. Bannerghatta National Park offers safari among white tiger, Bengal tiger, lion and bear, with a butterfly park attached. The day ends at Bangalore Palace, the Tudor-style summer residence of the Mysore maharajas.

Overnight in Bengaluru

Day 13 Bengaluru: Departure

Transfer to Bengaluru airport for your onward flight, carrying home thirteen days of caves, temples, palaces and a good deal of hospitality.

Departure

Practical notes

Best time to visit

October to March across the whole route. The Deccan and the Tamil Nadu coast are both uncomfortable from April, and the west coast monsoon runs June to September.

Getting there

Arrive into Mumbai (BOM) and depart from Bengaluru (BLR). Internal flights and two overnight trains are built into the itinerary and arranged for you.

Ideal duration

Thirteen days is what this route needs. Shortening it means dropping either the cave complexes or the Hoysala temples, and both are the reason to come.

Pace

Active. Two internal flights, two overnight trains and several full sightseeing days. Rewarding, but not a rest.